

ETHICAL HACKING

Question

A person with no malicious intent scan random IP addresses on the internet "just to see what's out there" without permission. Argue both sides: is this person "a grey hat," and what ethical line have they crossed, if any?

Answer:

INTRODUCTION

The rapid growth of internet has made cybersecurity an essential part of protecting personal, business and government information. One common technique is IP scanning, which involves sending requests to internet-connected devices to determine whether they are active. Consider a situation where a person scans IP addresses on internet simply "to see what's out there" without any malicious intentions.

UNDERSTANDING GREY HAT HACKING

Hackers are generally classified into three categories.

→ White hat hackers.

Their objective is to identify vulnerabilities & improve system security.

→ Black Hat Hackers.

Their activities include data theft, malware distributions, ransomware attacks, & unauthorized access.

→ Grey hat hackers:

Although their intentions may be positive or simply driven by curiosity, their actions may still violate ethical principles and legal regulations.

Argument 1: Why this person can be considered a Grey hat Hacker.

The reasons supporting this view include:

- * The individual is only collecting publicly accessible information.
- * No attempt is made to exploit vulnerabilities.
- * No files are modified or deleted.
- * No malware is installed.
- * The purpose is exploration rather than attack.
- * The activity may help the individual learn about cybersecurity.

Argument 2: Why this behaviour is still
ethically wrong.

Lack of consent:

Ethical hacking depends on authorization.
Without permission,

→ The owner cannot approve activity,
Verify purpose or scan as potential
cyberattack.

The Ethical line that has been crossed:

The Ethical boundary crossed is performing
Security-related actions without authorization.

- Respect for ownership
- Respect for Privacy
- Responsible conduct.

Counter-argument:

This reasoning includes:

- * Devices connected to public internet already
respond network requests.
- * Search engines continuously scan websites
- * Many scanning tools collect only publicly
available information.

My Evaluation :

In my Opinion, the person should be considered a grey hat hacker rather than a black hat hacker because there is no evidence of malicious event, data theft or system exploitation.

Conclusion :

Scanning IP addresses without permission occupies a gray area in cybersecurity ethics. The absence of malicious intent suggests that the individual is closer to grey hat hacker than criminal attacker. Therefore, curiosity should always be balanced with ethical responsibility and legal compliance.